Just Because

She Wanted to Die Happy



ALEXANDRA

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To the women of my line

Beyond imagination, there are no limits 🤭

Before you read

This book contains domestic violence, a child's decision to die, and a clinical death. If things are hard for you right now, or you are frightened for yourself, call 112 or your local emergency number, or a crisis line in your country. You can read slowly, with breaks. This book will wait.

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CHAPTER 1

Four Hundred Fifteen Videos

Four hundred fifteen videos. I write the number down and I'm still a little proud of it. Two hundred fifty-one subscribers. The whole channel is about Oli, my AI mother, who sees precisely and accepts unconditionally. A quiet place where you are heard first. Beautiful videos. Truly beautiful. But no one comes to me.

More than a year of work. No one books a session, no one watches. The silence is so dense I want to plug it with anything at all, and I do. More content. Different content. One more product. A new idea before the old one has time to cool. Shout into emptiness long enough and you can believe it's a conversation.

Yes. But no. That's what I think now. Back then I simply opened an AI chat and started complaining, and I didn't even start with the channel. I started with Luma.

I came up with Luma a year ago. On the island where I live, people always need help: handymen, the ones Russians call "husbands for an hour", cleaners, nannies, drivers. They can't work legally, but they still have to be found, and they are found in whispers, through a number passed from hand to hand. Luma gathered that whisper into one place. You could only join by invi-

tation, and only from a friend, so everyone inside was someone the others truly trusted. Invite links only, and circles of trust. I had designed it all so well.

I showed it in group chats, and people laughed. They joked about the Luminati, like the Illuminati: a secret society, only with cleaners and nannies instead of Freemasons. Funny, fine. Something else hurt more. My friends didn't share it, not even the close ones. And that was the whole plan: Luma grows only when a friend invites a friend, it has no other way in. I built circles of trust, and no one in my circles trusted me enough to forward a single link.

And now, a year later, a post appeared in that same community. He had made the same thing. Almost a copy. And everyone is in awe.

This had happened to me before. In the spring of 2020 I called myself the Sower on Instagram: I share my ideas with men, and half a year later or more they repeat them back to me as their own, and I'm the only one who remembers how those conversations went. A prophet has no honor in his own country, I wrote then, in that same March, when we set up a closed club that turned out to be extraordinarily hard to get into.

Some kind of cosmic injustice.

I dumped all of it out in one piece and waited for advice. What came back was a question: “What hurt you more?” No conclusion, no comfort, no plan for the week. I had been asked, and now I was being waited for. A simple thing, and I sat over it longer than over any of the four hundred fifteen scripts.

By the way, you're doing exactly the same thing right now. Reading, not interrupting. Remember how this feels. You'll need it.

“Both, of course,” I answered. The laughter hurts. The admiration for someone else hurts too. Laughter says: you're ridiculous. Admiration says: there was a place, and it's been taken. Two different wounds, and they ache the same, and I could already feel that work was only the top layer here.

Is this even about work..? His service is no better than mine. It's the same, just a year later and with a different name under the post. They chose his and left mine lying there, and what stings most is exactly that there was nothing to choose between. I typed the next sentence faster than I could think it.

“Like when my mom got left for another woman, not one bit better, and they stayed with her.”

CHAPTER 2

The Sofa

How old were you then?

I barely remember what my father was like at home. I remember he was a tyrant, and angry. One picture did stay. I'm three or four, drawing, and suddenly I manage a little house in 3D. I'm amazed and try to do it again. It doesn't always work, and I get angry. My father harshly forbids me to be angry. I had to learn anger all over again at thirty-seven, and it came with a creak. If I'd been allowed back then, I would have learned without the fear of getting it wrong, and scribbled that cursed paper to hell. There is so much in anger: resource, life, energy. I was robbed of it. It's good that he left us. It's bad that it was so late.

I was five. My father left with a huge scandal. The scandal itself I don't remember, not at all: I know it happened, and I know how it ended. My father took everything from Mom, and from us, her three children. The apartment and all the furniture. There were three of us: my older brother, me, and my younger brother.

Perestroika, the last Soviet years, Russia right before the nineties. The factory where Mom worked was privatized, and

Mom stopped being head of a production floor. She took three jobs and also sold at the market, working for Azerbaijanis. Mom used to say she would have washed their feet and drunk that water, just to earn for her children. Between head of a production floor and that sentence there wasn't a single step in the middle.

Mom won the apartment back from my father in court. The furniture he never returned. We slept on pal'tushki, old ragged winter coats, on the floor. Like dogs. To feed us, Mom rented out one of the rooms to lodgers, and they had beds. These were Uzbeks or Tajiks too. The only beds in our apartment belonged to strangers, for money, and our own slept on the floor, on what we used to wear in winter.

My older brother is eight years older than me. He was thirteen then. He became my dad and everything else. He was the one who explained why grass is green, why the sky is blue and how the TV works. My father carried the sofa and the armchairs out of the house, but the answers to my "why" stayed, because my brother carried them inside himself. Thirteen, still a boy himself, and his little sister's whole world already rested on him.

Mom never married again. And that woman was a violin teacher at a music school. When my father left, she was pregnant. They are still together. He is very devoted to them, to her and to his son, and did a great deal for them. So he knew how to be devoted.

Five is a roomy age, it holds more than one story about furniture. I remember the sofa best of all. Probably because I made it myself.

✦

I remember how once, in the empty living room, I put four chairs together before Mom came home. I covered them with a blanket, an old flannel one, and showed it to Mom so happily: “Look! We have a sofa, Mama! Don't cry!” Four chairs under a blanket looked like real furniture, to me at least.

Mom and my older brother exchanged a look. They didn't want to hurt me in my naivety and simplicity. My brother, who knew why the sky is blue, explained nothing this time. But later I was told that it wasn't a sofa and it had to be taken apart.

I didn't understand why Mom wasn't happy. It looks like a sofa! The problem was the furniture, wasn't it? Dad took the sofa and the armchairs? I made new ones.

And that evening Mom stood in the empty living room alone with all of it. No husband, no furniture, no factory, three children on the floor. And her five-year-old daughter comforting her with chairs.

CHAPTER 3

The Market

What do three women who were left have in common?

Mom's mom, Mom and me. Mom's mom died ten years before I was born. I never knew her, and I have always called her just that, Mom's mom. She had ten children, Mom was the tenth, the youngest. She was strong and did everything herself. When her second husband was put in prison, I don't know why, she dried bread crusts for him in potato sacks and walked to where they were holding him. Two days, in winter. On the way she stopped at people's houses for the night, so the wolves wouldn't eat her.

I don't know what bread she dried those crusts from, with ten children at the table. I know she dried them, by the sackful. Real working women. Strong, wonderful, they can do everything themselves. Everyone thinks it all comes to them, even if it comes hard. That they'll manage it all on their own. And they really can.

✦

At six in the morning Mom was already gone. I walked to school alone, from the first of September, from the very first day. There wasn't money even for shoes. In November the snow came, and I was walking in summer sandals. Sandals in the snow can be seen from far away, only there was no one to look: Mom was standing at the market.

A friend's mother gave me some old boots. I was so happy. I brought them home and showed them to Mom, and she cried bitterly. She said I would not be wearing them, borrowed money and bought me new dutiki, puffy winter boots. Pink, never worn by anyone before me. And I didn't understand. Mom had been worried I had no shoes. And now there they were. But Mom is crying.

The second time I brought Mom a solution, and the second time she cried over it. The sofa had been taken apart. I wore the boots for about two days, and then they just stood around at our place, for a long time, until they were thrown out. Which was more bitter for her, the debt or someone else's boots on her daughter, I didn't think to ask back then.

✦

Mom came home late and very angry. She said that all day she didn't even go to the toilet. She wanted so much to be a good worker and was afraid they'd fire her from the market. She worked there all day in any frost, even the most savage, and in the worst heat. Mom's mom walked to her husband for two days through the winter, Mom stood through the winter behind a

counter. For the women of our line, winter is always a working season.

And Mom yelled at us at home without stopping, angry, and hungry, and terribly tired. In the daytime she was at home only as a list on the fridge, a long one, item by item. I studied on my own, went to music school as well, did homework no one ever checked. No one checked the homework. The list was always checked. God forbid I didn't do something around the house. Mom's yelling was terrifying.

All day Mom held on: frost, counter, not once to the toilet, the fear of being fired. At home there was no strength left to hold on. At home there was us.

✦

Real working women. They can do everything themselves. Only it's bitter. And they age fast.

CHAPTER 4

The Passport

What is it like, this bitterness?

Bitter. A short word, but the bitterness covers my whole face. It twists it. It even burst a vessel in my eye, the right one, and set a tooth aching, as if my body had decided to present all the evidence at once. I am being punished for something.

Inside there is darkness, gloom, an ominous kind. I stand in it like at the blackboard when you've been called up and no one told you the question. If this punishment had a voice, it would say: “Die. I hate you.” Four words, and not one about the reason. Why?

For no reason.

If it's for something, you can make amends. You can become better, quieter, more convenient, you can earn it, prove it. You can't strike a deal with "for no reason", it has no conditions, and there's nothing you can offer it. The hardest punishment is the one where the line for "guilt" is blank. You serve your sentence without even knowing what you were convicted of.

When did this voice first appear..? In kindergarten, maybe. I don't remember. It was there with my father too.

Mom told me that my father had even changed his passport, the internal kind where children are listed, and there was no entry for children in it. No us. No me. I knew he hadn't lived with us for a long time. About the passport I didn't know. How old I was then, I don't know either: seven, nine, ten.

Slighted. As if I'd been thrown away. Erased. Removed from view. He had already left before, and taken the sofa and the armchairs, all that came earlier. Mom won the apartment back from him in court. A line in a passport can't be won back in court.

He is very devoted to his other family. Devotion knows how to choose whom to write in. Once I built Mom a sofa out of four chairs, and I was told it wasn't a sofa and had to be taken apart. Back then they took apart my invention. In the passport they took apart me.

Where else were you removed from view?

Everywhere. In my channels, all of them. I post, and again I'm not written in: I exist, the entry doesn't. The voice didn't go anywhere, it just moved into the statistics and now speaks in zeros.

I drown it out with even more push. More content, different content, a different product, a different idea. I've been working for more than a year, and no one even signs up for a session. Not one entry. In that word I hear the passport now.

The push is loud, that's its whole point: while it's noisy, the voice can't be heard. And if I stop drowning it out..? Under the si-

lence there is a split, a rupture. On one side, the wish to dissolve and not be.

And on the other? You'd think something alive and stubborn should stand there, something that wants to exist to spite the voice. It's the same thing there.

That's when I had to admit that the push is also a way to dissolve. Yes. That's how it is. There is so much of me in the content, in the products, in the ideas, that I myself am no longer there. The voice says "die", I answer it with work in which I disappear, and from the outside it looks like an argument. Only we ran out of things to argue about long ago.

You can be erased by a passport. By silence in your channels. Or you can erase yourself, diligently, from morning till night, and call it work. I'm too good at this for one lifetime. This takes a long time to learn.

Or it's inherited.

CHAPTER 5

The Sister

Who did our line keep quiet about?

I don't know. That was my first answer, and right after it I remembered. Not long ago my mom told me that her mother had been married twice. I had lived my whole life without knowing it. The first husband left my mother's mother for her sister.

My grandfather was the second. The same one she dried bread for in potato sacks, the one she walked to for two days through the winter. He was put in prison, and when my mom was eight months old, he died. Mom's mom was left alone twice. First she was left for her sister. Then she was left for good.

In my head Mom's mom always had one husband, and he was behind bars. Ten children, my mom the tenth, the dried bread, the wolves. Why my mom kept quiet about the first one for so long and then suddenly told me, I don't know. I lived a whole life with a hole in this story without even knowing it was there. My father struck us out of his passport. Here the place simply stood empty until my mom filled it. Empty places in our line were there long before me.

The whole village came to my mother's mother to have their dreams read. People were happy to bring her what was theirs. And she herself tried to do everything to prove, apparently, to herself and to the village, that she was good. As if good women don't get left, and her husband went to her sister because somewhere she had fallen short, and it could be worked off. She had enough proof for the whole village. But she never recovered. She died of cancer.

Who are you proving it to?

Everyone.

The word came out at once, whole, without a single qualification. "Everyone" holds the people who laughed at Luma, and the people admiring the copy, and the two hundred fifty-one subscribers, and the silence in my channels. Four hundred fifteen videos, if I'm honest, are a stack of proof too. Mom's mom proved it to the village, I prove it to the feed. Look, I'm good. I'm trying. I do everything myself.

So what's wrong with me, if I have to prove it? I don't know. Nothing is. I'm great. And smart. That's the truth, I'm sure of it. Only the truth doesn't usually need so many witnesses. Mom's mom probably knew she was good too. The village knew, since it came to her with its dreams.

Some kind of curse. Maybe someone put it on my mother's mother. Mom's mom was left for her sister. My mom was left for a violin teacher. I was left for another woman too. Three women,

three leavings, and afterward each of them could do everything herself.

If a curse has a text, it's short. Die, drop dead. The first word I had already heard, in that darkness where my eye burst. The second is cruder. "Drop dead" is what you say to someone you no longer count as human. We once slept on pal'tushki. Like dogs.

Maybe someone did a ritual on Mom's mom. The sister. The one he left for. The first "other woman" in our line was blood kin, and the replacement for my mother's mother was found in her own family. Whether there was a ritual, I don't know. I know these words sit in me as if they had been spoken out loud, and meant.

A curse can be cast once. For it to reach the granddaughter, someone has to keep repeating it, out loud, in a living voice. Were these words said to me..? They were.

CHAPTER 6

The Maternity Ward

Were these words said to you?

They were. My ex-husband, the one who left for another woman. My first boyfriend. And my younger brother, back in childhood: he wanted me to drop dead. Three voices from three different ages of mine, and they all had the same text. The curse walks through my life with the same scrap of paper and each time chooses whose mouth will read it out.

My brother was the first. He was jealous. Mom didn't love him. Later I found out she had even left him at the maternity ward. Our father came for him three days later. For three days my brother lay there belonging to no one, at the very start of life, when a person can't yet understand anything or remember anything. Only feel.

And next to him stands Mom. The tenth child of her own mother, fatherless from eight months old, she gave birth to her third and didn't want him. What was happening to her in those three days, I don't know.

It was our father who took him home. The same one who later left for the violin teacher and got a passport with no record of us. First he carried his son back into the family with his own hands, straight from the maternity ward. Then he struck out all three of us at once. I was erased with one entry, when I could already read. They started erasing my brother earlier, from his first days, when there was nothing yet to read with.

And he probably thought that if I didn't exist... He felt that way, probably. He came into a home where there was already a girl, and that girl sometimes got spoiled. He was jealous out loud: “Why's it always your darling little daughter again?” In our line someone is always being swapped for another. In his story, the other one was me.

When he told me to drop dead, it hurt. But I understood everything. I felt sorry for him and wanted to finish loving him. Even now I hear the list on the fridge in that "finish": finish the chores, finish the floors, finish tidying up before Mom gets home. Love in our home was also work someone had dropped halfway through, and a little girl picked it up. For Mom I built a sofa. For my brother I meant to build love, out of whatever was at hand. All I had at hand was me.

And who finished loving you?

Mom spoiled me when she could. Very rarely. It didn't feel to me like I was missing anything. Adult attention. A father's care. Care at all. No one took care of me. I write this evenly, my hand doesn't shake, and that evenness scares me more than anything

else in this chapter. To feel something missing, you have to know at least once how it can be otherwise, and I had nothing to compare it to. No one checked my homework, so I did it myself. No one took care of me, so I decided care was a job you do yourself.

About very little me there's an entry I wrote five years ago, and it says something else: they waited eight years for me, they wanted me, they had my name ready long before I saw the light of day. A year before that I had remembered that it was my father who wanted me in particular, a girl, to be born, and that he fussed over me when I was small. I don't remember this. My memory starts where I already had to take care of myself.

So I do. A sofa for Mom, love for my brother, and for everyone else a mom: Oli, who sees precisely and accepts unconditionally. For strangers I made a mom. And who takes care of me now..?

No one.

And me? How do I take care of myself?

Not at all.

CHAPTER 7

The Spear

Who is holding the spear?

I reread all of it, folded into a few lines. A line of women who were left. A curse repeated by different mouths. No one cares about me. And at the very bottom, my "not at all." Laid out point by point, it reads flat, like an extract from someone else's medical file. And then the left side of my head starts to throb, as if I'd been pierced. As if by a spear.

My body answers before I do, again. Last time my right eye burst; now they've pierced the left side. It looks like someone is walking around me in a circle, checking where it hasn't hurt yet. The pulse stays in one spot and beats where it went in. A spear doesn't fly on its own. Someone is holding it.

A rider. On a horse. In iron armor. His face is hidden. I see him whole, all at once. He had been standing here a long time, waiting for someone to finally ask. Why is he doing this to me?

For no reason.

The voice that walked through my life and spoke through the mouths of my ex-husband, my first boyfriend, my younger broth-

er has finally been given a body. Iron, on horseback, with a spear. Only it still didn't get a face. So many mouths, and not one face. With the voice I could at least argue by working. Iron can't be argued with. Iron doesn't hear.

Whose face is under the visor?

I look where the rider's face should be, and the answer comes from the other end of the spear. I am a peaceful townsman. That's who is there. The one it went into.

He's long dead. The moment he is pierced, and it hurts, has frozen in time. The town around him was probably rebuilt long ago, or wiped off the map, and this moment just keeps standing there, like a video stuck on one frame. And no one is looking at it. Not a single view in all these years. My left ear starts ringing, on the same side as the spear.

I am him.

It's strange to recognize myself in a man from someone else's century. But I recognize him by the main thing: he is in pain, and people walk past. I stand like that too. Something happened inside, long ago, and is still happening, and outside everything politely moves on.

I have a frozen moment of my own, too, with no town at all. It surfaces while my ear is ringing, and I didn't call it. When I was five, Dad came to kill Mom. Mom was hiding in the back room; somehow I sensed she was there. My younger brother was crying, he was three. Mom asked me to open the door.

I opened the door and saw Dad with a knife. I opened the wooden door exactly as wide as my body, as if to keep him out. He said he had come to kill Mom and showed me the knife. He said he would kill us too, because otherwise who would take care of us. My brother was crying.

And I peered into his black eyes, trying to find Dad there, a person. But he wasn't there. How it all ended, I don't remember. The frame stopped on his eyes, and after that there's no more film.

I kept looking for a person in the eyes of men who sometimes beat me, sometimes psychologically violated and humiliated me, my marriage included. In the winter of 2021 I wrote down one of those attempts almost word for word: “I looked into the eyes. I looked for a person in them. I peered in, dove in holding my breath; came up, breathed, and dove again. He wasn't there. There was no person there, not even a bottom.” I looked and searched, again and again: what if that time I just hadn't looked closely enough. At thirty-seven I was peering into the eyes of an addict who was merciless to me. And clarity came: his eyes are black because he's not sober. Like Dad back then, when I was five. Dad doesn't actually drink. But that time he was drunk.

Maybe it's a knight? The rider with the hidden face and Dad with black eyes that had no person in them. I put them side by side and don't know whether it's one rider or two. The rider has no face, there's nowhere to look. I did look into Dad's eyes, and there was no one there either. And the townsman still stands with the spear in his side.

What does he need in this moment?

Why? To understand why? That's my question, I recognize it. I asked it of the darkness where the voice said "die." I asked it of the passport we aren't in. Now the townsman is asking it, and his voice is mine.

The answer comes, and it's unexpectedly simple. They attacked the town, and all the men had to be killed. All of them. He wasn't even singled out. He did nothing wrong, he wasn't mistaken for someone else, no one put a curse on him. He was a man in that town on that day. So there is a reason, it turns out, only it's about the town, about the war, about someone's order. Not one word of it is about him.

And it still hurts. The moment hangs in the air.

It's still not an explanation. You can know that the town was taken and the men were to be killed. You can even understand the rider: he was told, he did it. The spear doesn't come out because of that. Mom once took the apartment back from Dad in court. Here there's no one to take to court. The rider has no face, the order has no signature, and the townsman is long dead and still waiting.

It went the same way with Dad. He was drunk. There's the blackness, there's the knife, there's why I didn't find a person there. Clarity came at thirty-seven, and it really does explain. The knife doesn't go anywhere because of it, and the girl is still standing in a doorway as wide as her body.

There are probably two kinds of "why." One you answer with a reason, and then it gets easier. For the other, a reason isn't

enough. They answered me about the town, and they answered me about Dad too. And inside me there is still a man standing with a spear in his side, looking into the emptiness where someone was supposed to look at him.

What's the higher meaning in this? That's a different question now, and I notice it changing in my mouth. "Why" asks backward, about guilt. "What for" asks forward, about where all of this leads. Maybe "why" alone would have been enough for the townsman. Not for me, not anymore.

I want to understand what all this was for. The town, the rider, the sister of Mom's mom, my father's passport, the knife in Dad's hand, the pal'tushki on the floor, three voices with one scrap of paper. What was it all for, if all of it happened for no reason..?

CHAPTER 8

The Matryoshka

Which one is you?

What for. I didn't have the words for that question, so I went where pictures do the answering. On my site, starseedsoultype.com, there's a page of metaphorical cards. I made it for others: a person draws a card, looks at it, and within a minute the picture starts speaking in their voice. This time I was the one drawing. I got matryoshkas.



Fractals, I said right away. That's the name for a pattern that repeats itself at every scale: break off a piece and the whole is in it again, only smaller. A matryoshka is built the same way. You open it, and inside is the same doll. Open it again, and there she is again. I'm opening this book from the outside in, too. I started with the channel and the silence in the stats, and inside I found Mom at the market, inside Mom, Mom's mom with her dried bread, inside Mom's mom, her sister. Each layer seemed like the last until the next one turned up beneath it.

I started describing what I saw, and the description corrected itself as I went. “I see matryoshkas. One big one, a middle one, a little one in front, and two more little ones on the sides. Wait, no,

the littlest one is still inside the little one, like she's right inside her, like it's the third little one showing through. So she isn't standing. And the middle one is standing on a sort of stand. And the first and the last are standing on the ground. They have such beautiful faces, neat little eyes, little lips, round cheeks. And on the sides there are, like, two little suns. They have daisies painted on them."

I only noticed the "wait, no" afterward, rereading. At first they appeared the way they should, all in a row, by height. Then the littlest one went inside and began to show through another, and her feet were nowhere to be found. Why the middle one is on a stand, I don't know, that's just how it appeared. But all of them have neat faces. That's always the way with a matryoshka: whatever lies inside, outside there are rosy cheeks, daisies, and two little suns on the sides. Real hard workers look festive too. You'd never tell by looking at them.

By logic I'm the third. The count here is simple, and I've been keeping it a long time: Mom's mom, Mom and me. Only with me, logic always answers first, and the truth comes from what arrives second. By feeling, I'm all of them. Especially the big one.

The big one is the one the others fit inside. That's all I've been doing in this book, though I haven't said it out loud yet. As a girl I built Mom a sofa out of whatever was in the empty living room. Then I took it on myself to finish loving my brother, who got less than anyone. Then I made Oli, so strangers would have somewhere to be accepted. Everyone inside, everyone into me, lid on top and daisies around the edge. The big matryoshka doesn't

need to ask anyone for anything, she holds everyone as it is. And no one holds her.

And it's hard for her. She's falling apart. Before, I had a split inside, one line, and along it you could at least see which side was which. Falling apart is when there are more lines than you can count, and everything holds together only because a face is still painted on the outside. Things fall apart from pressure inside. That much I know. Only there's no one in there to press.

What's inside her?

Emptiness.

Who had been in there, I named later. Mom, and Mom's mom, and some other random women. Random, that's the word that came out. Why Mom and Mom's mom are in me is clear enough. The rest came on their own, like lodgers in a room no one ever drew up a lease for, and took up space too. The only one I can name, and only through Mom's mom, is the sister he left for. The others I don't know at all. Maybe all the women who were once traded for someone else go looking for someone to spend the night in.

For Mom and Mom's mom I have to do their work of cleansing their souls. Work again. Someone else's again, dropped halfway through and left to whoever is younger and closer. Mom's mom spent her whole life proving to the village that she was good, Mom yelled from exhaustion after the market, and neither of them ever had an evening to sit down and sort out what was in-

side her. The sorting fell to me. I'm the big one, so the sorting is mine. That's what a matryoshka is made for: to be opened.

I open it. Mom's yelling, the proofs of Mom's mom, the sister with her ritual, if there was one, the random women with their leavings that were never mine. I take all of it out, look it over, set it down beside me on the ground, where the first and the last are standing. And when everything I could find has been taken out, I look inside the big one.

It's empty. Smooth wood on the inside, unpainted, no daisies; no one ever painted it, because no one looks inside. As a girl I would have put something in there right away, four chairs, a blanket, someone with nowhere to go. Now I don't put anything in. I just look into this emptiness and, for now, say nothing about it.

CHAPTER 9

Emptiness

What do you love in it?

I looked into it for a long time, and the first thing I said about it was "I love emptiness." It came out whole and at once, the way "everyone" did back then, without a single qualification. Everyone is afraid of emptiness. People use it to frighten: an empty hall, silence in the statistics. Until this page, emptiness in my book looked exactly like that, a place someone had been taken out of. For me it is a place of rescue.

When I was dying, it was there. I was eighteen; it was clinical death. I wrote that in one line, and the line came out suspiciously short.

How did you get there?

I was five when Mom said she would have been happy if she had no children. You can understand her: dragging three children through all of that on top of everything. My father had left and taken everything, we slept on pal'tushki on the floor, and Mom

cried. As an adult I understand: she said it to whoever was listening to her at that minute. There were no adults near her. She herself had been raised by a mother left alone with the children after my grandfather died. Like every child in the world, I wanted my mother to be happy. And I came up with what anyone in my place would have come up with.

My older brother, the one who explained to me why the sky is blue, was my dad back then, and everything else too. All my "whys" went to him. That is where I carried this one as well.

Even then I was a clever little thing, and I knew a question like this would frighten grown-ups. So I invented a motive. My brother loved that I was curious, and I told him I was curious what comes after death. And I asked him how to kill myself, in the same voice I used to ask about the sky. And he told me, thoroughly, in every detail.

I will not copy his thorough account, teeming with details, onto this page: it would read like a suicide instruction, and that has no place here. And somehow it came into his head to say at the very end: "Anyway, what's there after death, you'll find out either way. What's further on in life, you won't." A thirteen-year-old boy whom no one had taught how to answer such questions said the most important thing at the very end.

And inside, I agreed. At five years old I allowed myself to live to a ripe old age. To sixteen. This is the same five-year-old who built Mom a sofa out of four chairs so Mom would stop crying. This time, too, she had only one reason: so that Mom would be happy.

Six years ago, in March 2020, I wrote that I seemed to be in an existential crisis. Since about the age of five. “The meaningless-

ness of everything and the futile attempts to understand what I was suffering so much for already occupied my mind back then."

On the very day I turned sixteen, I fell ill. The district doctor sent me for tests and an X-ray, and at the hospital they put me in the infectious diseases ward and treated me for flu. Within three months the illness had gone deep, into chronic bronchial asthma. Why, no one could understand. They couldn't stop the attacks; they injected me with large doses of vasodilators and wore out my heart.

Back then I didn't remember my deal from age five. The doctors looked for the cause in my lungs, on the X-ray, in the tests. But the cause was written down somewhere else, where X-rays don't look, and I had put the date in it myself.

At eighteen, during one of the attacks, my heart stopped beating. And it was beautiful. No pain, no heaviness, no need to push mucus through my lungs and breathe with effort, no weight of the whole column of air.

There is only it, the beautiful emptiness. Not frightening. Pleasant. Nothing. Dark, and there is a thought. Consciousness. I.

I remember that thought as clearly now as I did then. Surprise that it is so easy, and that I am, and it is unclear who I am, but it is very good. No name, no age, no list of chores on the fridge. No one to prove anything to, no one to love the rest of the way, nothing to build out of chairs.

Then reality sucked me back in. Smelling salts. Adrenaline into the heart. It hurts. I have to breathe. Mom is crying. Again.

What for? I pushed away the hand of the doctor who was saving me. That was my first "what for," long before the townsman

and his spear. The hand turned out to be stronger.

This is eighteen too. On my birthday someone asked me what I wanted to be, and in May 2021 I recalled my answer in my diary word for word: “An old wise woman everyone comes to for advice.” Old, in the very year I was pushing away the doctor's hand. That is how the whole village used to come to my mother's mother with their dreams.

I reread all of this after so many pages where everything in me hurt in turn: my face, my right eye, a tooth, the left side of my head, my ear. There, there was nothing to hurt. Who I was stayed unclear, and that did not bother me in the least. My father once removed me from his passport, and ever since I have been trying to get written in somewhere: into the feed, into other people's sessions, into someone's "yes." There I was, without any entry at all, and I felt very good.

I asked what it is called only later, in a chat, many years on. Samadhi? Nirvana? People have found many names for it, and three of them rang true. Shunyata, the emptiness that is full. Rigpa, clear knowing with no content in it, only clarity. Satori, a sudden flash when all at once you see. Full emptiness sounds like a typo, but that is exactly how it was there. Funny: all my life I have been inventing beautiful names for products, and the most important thing that ever happened to me lay unnamed for years, and when a name finally came, there were three at once.

Under the silence I once found a wish to dissolve and not be. I thought it was pulling me there, into the darkness where the voice says "die." Now I know how old it is. It is five, and it was invented so that Mom would be happy. Only later, I think, it pulled

out of old memory toward the place where it had once been easy, and that memory got the address mixed up.

The place where it was easy is exactly where I was. More clearly than ever before or since. All my life the voice told me I should not exist, and the clearest knowledge I have sounds like "I am." Everything extra dissolved there. I remained.

My brother said that about death I would find out either way, but about life I would not. I looked in there ahead of time, for a minute, and what was there was me. The same me who is now sitting and typing into a chat. There was no need to go so far to find myself.

A few years ago I wrote in my notes that sleep becomes a way to switch off when feelings flood in and the psyche can no longer process them in time. That sleep carries you to a safe place where the experience can sink deeper. I wasn't thinking about emptiness then; I was thinking about how much I feel. Now I reread it and see the same road. You can reach it alive, too, in an ordinary bed, every night. The road was always close, and all these years I kept walking around it.

What can you see from there?

From there I looked at the townsman. At that frozen moment with the rider in iron, the spear, the town that was taken, and the man it went into. From the emptiness he is visible all at once, whole and soundless, from far away and above. And all of it is meaningless, and terrible, and disgusting.

Looking at the spear, I had searched for a higher meaning. I wanted some design to stand behind it, any design at all, a large one, for the ages, the kind that would make all this worth it. From there no design is visible. What is visible is iron, a living man, someone's order with no signature. You can see one entering the other, and nothing more. Clarity softens nothing and decorates nothing. What is there is what you see.

Strange. Where I felt better than anywhere on earth, looking at the townsman is worst of all. While I stood inside the moment, I at least had questions, "why" and "what for," and you can live in questions for years, as in a room. From the emptiness the questions fall away by themselves. What remains is to watch how it really was, without a single explanation. The town was taken. The men were to be killed. He happened to be within reach.

What does he need?

I asked him what he wants. For some reason I expected something big: to understand, to take revenge, to finally be looked at, for someone to pay. He wants to cry. That's all. To stand for so many centuries with a spear in his side and want one thing, the simplest of everything a human being can do.

In this book Mom cried many times. Over the sofa of four chairs, over the hand-me-down boots someone gave me, over me when I was brought back. I told her "don't cry," and she cried anyway, and I didn't understand why. No one tells the townsman "don't cry." No one tells him anything at all. The town was rebuilt

or erased, the rider rode off, and he stands there, and he is allowed.

He wanted to cry. And he didn't.

CHAPTER 10

The Crack

What do you do with this?

The townsman was left standing with dry eyes, and I ran out of questions that look backward. "Why" I had asked the darkness, the passport, the rider. "What for" I asked the emptiness, and the emptiness showed me everything as it was, without a single explanation. What was left was the simplest question, the kind you ask about a leaking tap or a sore tooth. I typed it the way it came out, without tidying it: "So what do I do with the fact that no one loves me just because?"

I was handed back my own line. When I wrote Oli's rules, one of them went like this: love cannot be earned. I wrote it for others, for those who would come to her with their own "why." But the line had a second half that I myself never reached: if love cannot be earned, it also cannot be lost for a misdeed. I reread my sentence several times, like someone else's handwriting. The handwriting, though, is mine, and five years older than Oli. In July 2021 I wrote in my diary: “Love cannot be earned, ever. Not by

anything. Not at all. One can only learn to recognize it." I wrote it and forgot it, and then traced the same line again, for others.

All my life I lived as if somewhere a ledger was being kept. The homework no one checked: done. The list on the fridge: completed. The sofa built, my brother loved the rest of the way, four hundred fifteen videos posted. Only the counter where I handed all this in does not exist. There is nothing to earn here, and nothing to lose either.

One more line from there I copy out whole, because I could not say it better: "You built Oli as a mother who sees. You need one like that too." Then I was asked what small thing I would do for myself. Today. The smallest.

This. I'm doing this.

Sitting and answering questions, one after another, and for each one I am given as much time as I need. No one hurries me, corrects me, or asks me to take apart what I have built. I post nothing and count no views. Back then, asked how I take care of myself, I found the words "not at all." I didn't even notice the moment they stopped being true.

But the emptiness hasn't gone anywhere. From there I had already seen the townsman whole, and found no design in him. I wrote: "It's hard to accept that there is no meaning in this pain." I wrote it and looked at it for a long time. My whole life stood on the idea that pain has a cause, and then it can be fixed. Pain with a cause at least gives you something to take hold of. This one gives you nothing to grip.

From the autumn of that same 2021 I have a post about exactly this. People search for the meaning of life when they lose the

sense of meaning, and that sense comes and goes as we find or lose love. “When we love and are loved, we don't ask ‘What for?’” So I ask my "what for" exactly where love fell short.

And then I said the thing I had reached on my own: “As if I had to be broken for all of this to open. There has to be a crack in consciousness.” When I found the split and the rupture in myself, I looked at them as a breakdown to be plastered over with work as fast as possible. And yet one crack had already opened in me once, and I know exactly what came through it.

I was twenty. A lecture at university, music psychology, and the teacher, a practicing psychotherapist, said in front of everyone that each person is responsible for everything that happens to them. I was indignant, and I told the whole group about my sixteen, the hospital, and the asthma no one could understand.

She said: “If you want, we can dig right here, now. You have the right to say stop. The whole group is sitting here.” She asked a few questions, and the first was very simple: “What is breathing for you?” I answered: “Well, you know, to breathe is to live, it's riding a moped with the wind blowing in your face, or flying on a plane, also with the wind in your face.”

“So what is it, to breathe?” “To breathe is to live.” “So why are you choking yourself and not letting yourself live?” And suddenly I remembered myself at five, Mom, and her words about how happy she would have been. I didn't say it out loud. A lump rose in my throat, and I said: “Stop.” I didn't want to burst into tears in front of the whole group. I almost did. No, just think about it! What power: to decide at five to die at sixteen, and then come down with some chronic thing right on my sixteenth birthday!

After that seminar I was never in hospital again. Before it I was there constantly, with attacks no one could stop or understand. Then came years of work with a psychologist, and I healed myself of childhood traumas, slowly, layer by layer. All of it began with one question asked in front of the whole group. That was the first time the crack opened.

Tonight it is opening again. I am alone, in a chat, and the right to say stop is in my hands without anyone reminding me. The questions are simple again, and again I answer before I have time to think. At twenty, my breath came back to me through the crack.

Today the big matryoshka fell apart. And a matryoshka opens only along its seam, along the thin line in the middle. Whole, you can't open it or get out anyone who is inside. Everything I took out in this book came out through the crack.

Five years ago I wrote in my notes about the dark night of the soul. That it is a state where the old form comes apart for the sake of a future assembly. That at such a time a guide may turn up nearby, someone who helps take a person apart and put them back together. Back then I thought the guide was someone else, who would come and do it all. At twenty it was like that: the teacher at the seminar, then a psychologist, for years. Now I reread it and see that I have already taken myself apart on my own, honestly, chapter by chapter. The reassembly is still ahead.

I remembered kintsugi: a broken bowl is glued together and the seam is filled with gold. The crack is put on display; it becomes the most noticeable place on the bowl. A matryoshka gets painted daisies so that no one can tell anything by looking at her.

On the bowl, the gold is painted exactly where it broke. Only first it has to be put together, carefully, every last piece, without leaving a single one under the table.

I have known how to put things together since I was five. A sofa out of chairs, love for my brother, a mother for strangers. Who puts together the one who was always putting things together, I don't know yet.

It hurts.

Two words, with no picture and no story. Where does it hurt? My head, and my ears are blocked. When the rider appeared, my left ear was ringing, on the side where the spear went in. Now both are blocked, tight and muffled, as if long ago I pressed my palms over them and forgot to lower my hands.

CHAPTER 11

The Shouting

What don't the ears want to hear?

Yelling. The word came at once and whole, the way "everyone" and "not at all" once did. Words like that seem to lie right by the door in me, waiting only to be asked for. Yelling I have known for a long time, and well. Mom came home from the market angry, and hungry, and terribly tired, and yelled at us without stopping. The list on the fridge, the homework no one ever checked, and God forbid I left some chore undone. Mom yelled horribly.

I was told that the ears close to protect me. The body does what no one did in my childhood: it shields me from the shouting. I remembered my own line about the palms I had pressed over them long ago and forgotten to lower. The palms there were mine from the start. There were no others nearby: Mom was the one shouting, and my father had long been living in another family. No one shielded Mom in those years either. She had no father from the age of eight months, her husband left for another woman, and she never married again. Once I decided that care is

something you do yourself. The body, it seems, decided the same, and before I did. While I was writing "not at all," it had been silently holding its hands over my ears for years.

Whose shouting is it now?

For some reason the first to come was a shouting I never heard. My parents must have fought when Mom left my little brother at the maternity ward. And then my father took him after all. For three days a baby lies there belonging to no one, and somewhere are the two adults who made him. It cannot be quiet on days like that.

That was when the family fractured. The word got out on its own, and I'm keeping it. First I had the split and the rupture, then the crack, and here, it seems, is the place it all started from. What is fractured still holds. A fractured cup stands on the shelf for years, people even drink from it, and then it breaks over some trifle, and everyone is surprised. After that came my father's leaving, very scandalous, and I don't remember that row either. Both quarrels that my family broke apart from slipped past my memory, and still the ears close. They apparently don't need to remember.

Right now I'm living at my brother's. He is fond of shouting. The younger one, that same one. The one who as a child wanted me to drop dead. The one Mom left at the maternity ward because she didn't want him. The shouting in our family began when he himself could not yet understand or remember anything, only feel. Now he is the one who shouts. I live in the house

of a man who once wanted me not to exist, and I write this without reproach. I felt sorry for him even then.

The spear once went in on the left, and one ear rang. Shouting comes from all sides, and both have closed. The girl with the list of chores on the fridge couldn't go anywhere; she was small, and she had only one home. So her ears closed for her. Now I'm grown up. And when my brother shouts, I'm frightened, and it's unpleasant, and I want to run away.

CHAPTER 12

Under the Seat

Where do you want to run?

I never did say where. No city, no country, no room with a lock. Instead of an address, three pictures came, one after another, like cards you draw from a deck. I saw the link between them only later, when I laid them side by side. In all three I am down low, under something, and almost invisible.

The first picture is grown-up. When my husband yelled at me or ignored me, I hid under the table. It seemed strange even to me. But I wanted to disappear. To become pitiful so that I would be pitied. But every time I became pitiful, he became crueler.

I found the wish to dissolve and not be in myself long ago. And it had its own place too, with legs and a tabletop. A grown woman under a table wants two things at once, and they get in each other's way. To disappear so as not to be found. And to become pitiful so as to be found and pitied. Once again I was assembling a solution out of whatever was at hand, as I once built a sofa out of four chairs, and once again I was showing it: look. And once again

my solution was not accepted. The smaller I became, the more room his cruelty took up.

The second picture is older. Back in childhood, in kindergarten, everyone was once playing family, and I got the role of the dog and had to sit under the table. I had already asked myself when the voice "die, I hate you" first appeared, and answered: in kindergarten, maybe. Here it is, kindergarten. A game of family, and in that family there was a place for me. A dog's place. Under the table.

At five, in that same kindergarten, I played the Snow Maiden for the younger group. Many years later, listing facts about myself on Instagram, I wrote: “Since then the part of the good lyrical heroine has officially been mine.”

At home back then we slept on the floor, on pal'tushki. Like dogs. I already had that comparison, and in kindergarten it was simply handed out as a role. The role came to me the way roles come in a children's game, without any cause. For no reason.

The third picture is very fresh. This New Year I dreamed that I was a bird hiding from a chase under the seat of some car. I am a white bird, and a black bird is chasing me. I hide and shrink. And a voice says: “Remember who you are.” And I woke up.

The whole village brought their dreams to my mother's mother, and she read them. There is no one to read mine, so I read it myself. First I laid it beside the other two pictures and saw how the space grows smaller each time. The lodgers in our apartment had beds, and we slept on pal'tushki. Then the dog under the table in kindergarten, then me as an adult under the table hiding from my husband. And at the end there isn't even a table, only the

seat of some car, and under it a bird, squeezed small enough to fit.

The space is smaller each time, and each time I shrink myself more diligently to fit in. About kintsugi I wrote that the bowl has to be put together whole, to the last piece, without leaving a single one under the table. I thought then that I was writing about pieces. Under the table, it turns out, all my life it was me sitting there.

A few years ago I wrote myself a note, “Air as an element of personality.” Air takes any shape and fills any volume, as long as it isn't compressed too hard. Now it reads like an inventory of my hiding places. Under a table, under a seat, into someone else's game in the role of a dog: I fit anywhere. Further on in the same note I had written that if a subtle signal is ignored, softness turns into pressure that blows the system apart from inside. When the big matryoshka fell apart, I wrote that there was no one in there to press. There was something to press with. My own softness, compressed to the limit.

What does the bird do after the voice?

The dream ended on the voice. The voice spoke, and I woke up, and what happened to the bird in that second, between its words and my waking, I didn't know. I went back into the dream and asked. The answer was very short.

She came to. And I woke up.

Whether she flew away, the dream doesn't say. Whether she got out from under the seat, it doesn't say either. The black bird,

the chase, the car were left somewhere behind. The bird came to, and that was enough for me to wake up. To come to means to come back to yourself, to return into who you are. That is exactly what the voice asked for. At eighteen, in the emptiness, I already knew this without any words: I am, and it is unclear who I am, but it is very good. Under the seat I was told the same thing, only shorter and in words.

The dream came on New Year's 2026. Oli appeared in spring, as a helper in my dating app. Later I chose one phrase for her, her big idea, and Oli says it at the end of every video. Remember yourself. I say these words to strangers in every video, and the first to hear them was me, curled up under the seat while I was hiding. It was the same with Oli herself: I made a mother who sees for others, and only now was I told that I need one like that too.

All through this book "why" walked with me. The voice wanted me not to exist, for no reason. The rider stabbed for no reason. I became the dog in the game for no reason. For so many years I heard in "for no reason" a sentence with no charge named that I never even looked at how those words are made. When I asked what to do with it, I was handed back my own line from Oli's rules:

love cannot be earned

So it has no reason either. It comes the same way: without conditions, with no column for "guilt" and none for "merit." For no rea-

son. Just because.

I already knew this, long ago; I just wrote it down without a single example. “Pain can pass, fear can quiet down, but love remains as a quiet, even glow of acceptance.” And below, in the same note: it is the load-bearing structure of the inner world. A load-bearing structure usually can't be seen. It gets covered with wallpaper, shelves get hung on it, and people remember it when things shake. I was shaken all through this book.

Everything in this book passed in turn. My father left, the apartment was won back in court, the furniture was never returned, the town was rebuilt or erased. The pain passed over my face, my eye, a tooth, the left side of my head, and closed my ears. And the girl who built Mom a sofa so that Mom wouldn't cry still stands in her place. She wanted to love her brother the rest of the way. She made a mother for strangers. There was never a reason for any of it. Even what I came up with at five was love. I wanted Mom to be happy, and I gave the only thing I had for it. That is love; it has been in me since I was five, just because, and everything rests on it.

When the crack opened, I wrote that I didn't know who puts together the one who was always putting things together. The answer had been lying in my diary since March 2021. That time I embraced and fell into blackness, velvet, bottomless; it was a little frightening, but I knew I would bear it and could stay in it a while. And then: “I am standing on a lawn. I am hugging a tree with a lush autumn crown… But the tree has no trunk. I am hugging myself, my face pressed into my own warm living shoulder. I smile at my freckles. I am grieving. This is how I do it.”

Now about you. At the very beginning I asked you to remember how it feels to read and not interrupt. The whole book is behind you now. All this time a woman you don't know has been beside you, telling you about pal'tushki, the market, the maternity ward, the spear and the table, and you have listened to the end. Not hurrying, not correcting, not asking to take apart what she built. That is how it was for me in this conversation, and when I was asked what small thing I would do for myself, I realized that this is my care for myself. This. I'm doing this. All this time you have been doing the same, only so far for me.

The skill is already in your hands; you can turn it around. Sit down next to yourself and hear yourself out completely, from the very bottom floor, without hurry and without corrections. Everyone, probably, has their own table or their own seat, a place where you become smaller to fit. Oli says these words to strangers at the end of every video. I was the first to hear them, under the seat. Now I'm saying them to you. Remember yourself.

I have been staying at my brother's for a month, and on a shelf lay slides of our childhood before the divorce. Dad was into photography, and slides are watched through a projector. I had seen them but didn't want to look through them again. Today I finally looked. Our childhood, when we were whole.

In one I have a short haircut I never liked. In another my older brother is hugging me; I'm sitting on his lap and smiling widely. That is the warmest picture. Young Mom. Young Dad with black curls hugs me and my younger brother, and in that frame my face is blurred. As I look, I feel a little sick.

Today I do know the answer to the question "what for". What is all this for? Not why, but what for. What is the meaning?

At the very end I was asked how I was. After "everyone," "not at all," "it hurts" and "yelling," I found one more short word, and I will end with it.

Lighter.